Part of me really did want to do something totally outside the box, something that would make everyone in the family, in the country, sit up and say: *What the —?* Part of me wanted to drop out, disappear—as Mummy did. And other princes. Wasn't there one in India, a long time ago, a bloke who just walked out of the palace and sat under a lovely banyan tree? We'd read about him at school. Or, we were supposed to.

But another part of me felt hugely ambitious. People assumed that the Spare wouldn't or shouldn't have any ambition. People assumed that royals generally had no career desires or anxieties. You're royal, everything's done for you, why worry? But in fact I worried quite a lot about making my own way, finding my purpose in this world. I didn't want to be one of those cocktail-slurping, eyeroll-causing sloths everyone avoided at family gatherings. There had been plenty of those in my family, going back centuries.

Pa, in fact, might've become one. He'd always been discouraged from hard work, he told me. He'd been advised that the Heir shouldn't "do too much," shouldn't try too hard, for fear of outshining the monarch. But he'd rebelled, listened to his inner voice, discovered work that excited him.

He wanted that for me.

That was why he didn't press me to go to university. He knew it wasn't in my DNA. Not that I was anti-university, *per se*. In fact, the University of Bristol looked interesting. I'd pored over its literature, even considered a course in art history. (Lots of pretty girls took that subject.) But I just couldn't picture myself spending years bent over a book. My Eton housemaster couldn't either. He'd told me straight-out: *You're not the university type, Harry.* Now Pa added his assent. It was no secret, he said gently, that I wasn't the "family scholar."

He didn't mean it as a dig. Still, I winced.

He and I went round and round, and in my head I went back and forth, and by a process of elimination we landed on the Army. It made sense. It aligned with my desire to be outside the box, to disappear. The military would take me away from the prying eyes of the public and the press. But it also fitted with my hope of making a difference.

And it accorded with my personality. My prized toys as a boy had always been miniature soldiers. I'd spent thousands of hours planning and waging epic battles with them at Kensington Palace and in Highgrove's Rosemary Verey–designed gardens. I'd also treated every game of paintball as though the future of the Commonwealth depended on the outcome.